



A NOTE FROM STIX — COL (RET.), USAF

So you're headed to USU — and thinking Air Force?

Good. Here's the whole thing in one line: **do Air Force ROTC right there on campus, and your first move is one phone call.** I did a bunch of your homework below so you walk in already knowing the score.

THE PLAY

Join **Air Force ROTC at USU**. You take your normal classes and do ROTC alongside them. Four years later you walk away with **your degree AND a commission as an officer** (a 2nd Lieutenant) — and ROTC scholarships can pay your way while you're there.

Why I'd tell my own kid to do this

- ✓ **You finish as an officer.** Degree in one hand, commission in the other, on day one after graduation. That's a huge head start.
- ✓ **It fits the plan you already have.** You're going to USU anyway — ROTC lives on your campus, so nothing about your college plan changes.
- ✓ **The scholarships are real money.** A full ride on tuition is on the table, plus a monthly stipend and book money, all tied to the degree you're already earning.
- ✓ **I did this for a living for 25 years.** As an officer myself, this is the path I'd recommend to you 100%. If flying ever crosses your mind, this is the only door to it.

Your one move this week

Call USU Air Force ROTC (Detachment 860) and tell them you're an incoming student who wants in. Ask for the recruiting officer, Maj Krystal "Nova" Henry.

Recruiting **(435) 797-4120**
Email **det860@usu.edu**
Main line **(435) 797-8723**
Web **usu.edu/aerospace**

Opening line that works: "Hi, I'm starting at Utah State this fall and I want to join Air Force ROTC. Can you walk me through how to get started and what scholarships I might qualify for?" That's it — they'll take it from there.

The homework I did for you — skim this so you sound sharp on the call

Here's what I found on your questions. Know the gist walking in, then let the detachment confirm the details for *your* situation. The green italics are the things only they can nail down for you.

GETTING IN

How do I join as an incoming freshman?

At USU it's refreshingly simple: **register for the intro Aerospace Studies classes and show up** — that's the front door. It's roughly three 1-credit courses (Heritage & Values, Leadership Lab, and Physical Fitness Training). You'll also set up an online "WINGS" account. There's a **New Cadet Orientation on Saturday, Aug 29, 2026** at the Military Science Building.

Ask them: exactly which class sections to register for, and how to knock out the enrollment paperwork and uniform fitting before orientation.

Can I try ROTC my first year without committing to anything?

Yes — the first two years carry zero military obligation if you're not on a scholarship. You can explore it, decide it's not for you, and walk away with no strings attached. The commitment doesn't kick in until your junior year (or the moment you activate a scholarship).

HOW ROTC ACTUALLY WORKS

What's the weekly time commitment while I'm in school?

As a freshman/sophomore, plan on about **3–6 hours a week**: one Aerospace Studies class, a 2-hour Leadership Lab, and two physical-training sessions. Juniors/seniors bump up to ~7 hours (the class gets bigger). Nothing mandatory over winter break — with **one big exception: Field Training**, the summer before junior year (next question).

How do the first two years differ from the last two?

Big difference. The **first two years (the “GMC”)** are the intro/try-it-out phase — no obligation, you’re figuring out if it’s for you. The **last two years (the “POC,” junior + senior)** are the real officer track: you sign a contract, you draw a monthly stipend even without a scholarship, and you’re committed to commissioning. The summer in between is Field Training (below).

Is there summer training I need to plan around?

Yes — and this one is **mandatory**. **Field Training** is a roughly two-week camp at Maxwell Air Force Base in Alabama, the summer between your sophomore and junior year. **You must complete it to move into the last two years (the POC)** — and you first have to earn a slot for it (an “Enrollment Allocation”) based on your grades, fitness, and evaluations. Other than that one summer, your breaks are your own.

Does my major matter?

You can commission with **any major** — don’t let anyone tell you otherwise. That said, **scholarships favor technical and foreign-language majors** (roughly 80% of scholarships go to those fields). Bottom line: pick a major you’ll do well in, because a strong GPA matters more than the label.

Ask them: given the major I’m considering, does it help or hurt my scholarship odds?

SCHOLARSHIPS & MONEY

What scholarships can I get — and can I still get a 4-year one?

Two doors. (1) The **High School Scholarship** is applied for senior year of high school — if you’re already enrolling this fall, that window has likely closed for you, and that’s totally fine. (2) Your real play is the **In-College Scholarship (ICSP)**: you join as a cadet, perform, and the detachment competes you for a scholarship during your freshman/sophomore year. Scholarships come in **3- and 4-year** lengths depending on when you win one.

Ask them: is the high-school deadline actually past for me, and exactly how do I set myself up to win an in-college scholarship this year?

How and when do I apply?

For the in-college scholarship, there’s **no separate application form** — the detachment evaluates and nominates cadets based on grades, fitness, and major. In plain English: **your “application” is showing up, keeping your grades up, and crushing the fitness test**. They’ll set up your WINGS account and walk you through the paperwork.

What does a scholarship actually cover?

Full tuition + most fees, \$900/year for books, and a tax-free monthly stipend (\$300 as a freshman rising to \$500 as a senior). One honest heads-up: it does **not** cover room and board — so budget for housing/food separately.

COMMITMENT & TIMELINE — KNOW THIS BEFORE YOU DIAL

When do I sign a contract, and when am I locked in?

Not until you enter the POC (junior year), *or* the moment you activate a scholarship — whichever comes first. Before that, during the first two years as a non-scholarship cadet, **nothing binds you and you can leave for any reason.**

After I graduate and commission, how many years do I owe?

Here's the part worth knowing cold:

Active-duty service commitment (the “ADSC”)

- **Most (non-flying) jobs: 4 years** of active duty, starting the day you commission.
- **Pilot: 10 years** — but the clock starts the day you earn your wings, *after* ~1 year of pilot training (so realistically ~11–12 years total).
- **Other flying jobs: 6 years** — Combat Systems Officer, Air Battle Manager, and Remotely Piloted Aircraft pilot, starting after their training.
- **The scholarship doesn't add extra time** — the 4 years already covers taking the money. Only flying jobs extend it.

Quick eligibility check (so nothing surprises you)

U.S. citizen (or become one by the end of freshman year); pass a fitness test (push-ups, sit-ups, timed run) and a medical exam; keep a solid GPA (they want ~2.5+, and higher to win scholarships). Nothing here should be a problem — just know it's coming.

Ask them: “Is there anything else you'd tell a kid in my shoes that I don't know to ask?”

That's the homework. Now make the call — worst case you spend fifteen minutes learning your options; best case it's the first step toward paying for USU *and* becoming an officer. Proud of you for even asking the question. Now go get after it.

— Stix

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